

military band in Odense in 1879, playing horn and trombone.

From 1884 to 1886, Nielsen studied at the Copenhagen Conservatory, and in 1889 he became a violinist in the Royal Danish Orchestra. A scholarship enabled him to spend nine months in 1890–1891 traveling around Europe, where he met (in Paris) and married (in Florence) the Danish sculptor Anne Marie Brodersen. The marriage was troubled—Nielsen resented his wife’s protracted absences on work trips— but it produced three children and lasted until Nielsen’s death in 1931.

In 1894, the Royal Danish Orchestra premiered Nielsen’s exhilarating Symphony No. 1. Danish critic Charles Kjerulf wrote that it seemed to presage “a coming storm of genius,” and described the work as “wonderfully innocent and unknowing, as if seeing a child playing with dynamite.”

**“ Music is life, whereas the other arts
only represent and paraphrase life. ”**

CARL NIELSEN